The Philadelphia

By David Ives

AL is at the restaurant table, with the WAITRESS.

WAITRESS: Can I help you?

AL: What's the soup du jour today?

WAITRESS: Soup of the day you got a choice of Polish duck blood or cream of kidney.

AL: Beautiful. Beautiful! Kick me in a kidney.

WAITRESS: *(Writes it down.)* You got it.

INTRODUCTION

Two guys meet in a diner in New York, but they're both in very different states of mind. Al is in a Los Angeles state of mind. Nothing can faze him . . . even if it did he would just make it a Hollywood movie. Then there's Mark who finds the whole world is against him. He can't get a newspaper at the newsstand, aspirin at the drugstore, and the diner gives him a Cheesesteak when he wants a burger. That's right. Mark's trapped in a Philadelphia state of mind. (Music – Possibly the theme from the Twilight Zone)

It could be worse. You could be stuck in a Cleveland. It's like death without the advantages. The Philadelphia by David Ives.

(MARK enters, looking shaken and bedraggled.)

MARK: Al!

AL: Hey there, Marcus. What's up?

MARK: Jesus! Oh man. . . !

AL: What's the matter? Sit down.

MARK: I don't get it, Al. I don't understand it.

AL: You want something? Want a drink? I'll call the waitress

MARK: *(Desperate.)* No! No! Don't even try. *(Gets a breath.)* I don't know what's going on today, Al. It's really weird. Right from the time I got up.

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AL: What is it? What's the story?

MARK: Well-just for an example. This morning I stopped off at a drugstore to buy some aspirin. This is at a big drugstore, right? I go up to the counter, the guy says what can I do for you, I say, Give me a bottle of aspirin. The guy gives me this funny look and he says, "Oh we don't have that, sir." I said to him, You're a drugstore and you don't have any aspirin?

AL: Did they have Bufferin?

MARK: Yeah!

AL: Advil?

MARK: Yeah!

AL: Extra-strength Tylenol?

MARK: Yeah!

AL: But no aspirin.

MARK: No! And that's the kind of weird thing that's been happening all day. It's like, I go to a newsstand to buy the Daily News, the guy never even heard of it.

AL: Could've been a misunderstanding.

MARK: I asked everyplace-nobody had the News! I had to read the Toronto Hairdresser. Or this. I go into a deli at lunch time to buy a sandwich, the guy tells me they don't have any pastrami. How can they be a deli if they don't have pastrami?

AL: Was this a Korean deli?

MARK: This was a kosher from Jerusalem deli. "Oh we don't carry that, sir," he says to me. "Have some tongue." . . . . I just got into a cab, the guy says he doesn't go to 56th Street! He offers to take me to Newark instead! Looking at me like I'm an alien or something!

AL: Mark. Settle down.

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MARK: "Oh I don't go there, sir."

AL: Settle down. Take a breath.

MARK: Do you know what this is?

AL: Sure.

MARK: What is it? What's happening to me?

AL: Don't panic. You're in a Philadelphia.

MARK: I'm in a what?

AL: You're in a Philadelphia. That's all.

MARK: But I'm in . . .

AL: Yes, physically you are in New York. But metaphysically you are in a Philadelphia. You see, inside of what we know as reality there are these pockets, these black holes called Philadelphias. If you fall into one, you run up against exactly the kinda *stuff* that's been happening to you all day.

MARK: Why?

AL: Because in a Philadelphia, no matter what you ask for, you can't get it. You ask for something, they're not gonna have it. You want to do something, it ain't gonna get done. You want to go somewhere, you can't get there from here.

MARK: Good God. So this is very serious.

AL: Just remember, Marcus. This is a condition named for the town that invented the cheese steak. Something that nobody in his right mind would willingly ask for.

MARK: And I thought I was just having a very bad day . . .

AL: Sure. Millions of people have spent entire lifetimes inside a Philadelphia and never even knew it. Look at the city of Philadelphia itself. Hopelessly trapped forever inside a Philadelphia. And do they know it?

MARK: Well what can I do? Should I just kill myself now and get it over with?

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AL: You try to kill yourself in a Philadelphia, you're only gonna get hurt, babe.

MARK: SO what do I do?

AL: Best thing you can do is wait it out. Someday the great cosmic train will whisk you outa the City of Brotherly Love and off to someplace happier.

MARK: You're pretty mellow today.

AL: Yeah well. Everybody has to be someplace. *(WAITRESS enters.)*

WAITRESS: Is your name Allen Chase?

AL: It is indeed.

WAITRESS: There was a phone call for you. Your boss? He says you're fired.

AL: Cool! Thanks. *(WAITRESS exits.)* So anyway, you have this problem. . .

MARK: Did she just say you got fired?

AL: Yeah. I wonder what happened to my pigs' feet. . .

MARK: Al!? You loved your job! How can you be so calm?

AL: Easy. You're in a Philadelphia? I woke up in a Los Angeles. And life is beautiful! You know Susie packed up and left me this morning.

MARK: Susie left you?

AL: And frankly, Scarlett, I don't give a ****. I say, go and God bless and may your dating pool be Olympic-sized.

MARK: But your job? The garment district is your life!

AL: So I'll turn it into a movie script and sell it to Paramount. Toss in some sex, add a little emotional blah-blah-blah, pitch it to Jack and Dusty, you got a buddy movie with a garment background. Not relevant enough? We'll throw in the hole in the ozone, make it E.C.

MARK: E.C.?

AL: Environmentally correct. Have you heard about this hole in the ozone?

MARK: Sure.

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AL: Marcus, I love this concept. I embrace this ozone. Sure, some people are gonna get hurt in the process, meantime everybody else'll tan a little faster.

MARK: *(Quiet horror.)* So this is a Los Angeles. . .

AL: Well. Everybody has to be someplace.

MARK: Wow . . .

AL: You want my advice? Enjoy your Philadelphia. Sit back and order yourself a beer and a burger and chill out for a while.

MARK: But I can't order anything. Life is great for you out there on your cosmic beach, but whatever I ask for, I'll get a cheese steak or something . . .

AL: No. There's a very simple rule of thumb in a Philadelphia. Ask for the opposite.

MARK: What?

AL: If you can't get what you ask for, ask for the opposite and you'll get what you want. You want the Daily News, ask for the Times. You want pastrami, ask for tongue. So. Would you like a Bud?

MARK: I sure could use a . . .

AL: No. Stop. *(very deliberately.)* Do you want. . . a Bud?

MARK: *(Also deliberately.)* No. I don't want a Bud. *(WAITRESS enters and goes to the specials board.)*

AL: Good. Now there's the waitress. Order yourself a Bud and a burger. But do not ask for a Bud and a burger.

MARK: Waitress!

AL: Don't call her. She won't come. You're in a Philadelphia, so just figure, who needs her.

MARK: Who needs her.

AL: You don't need that waitress.

MARK: Hey, waitress! DROP DEAD! *(WAITRESS turns to him.)*

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WAITRESS: Can I help you, sir?

MARK: Uh-no thanks.

WAITRESS: Okay, what'll you have? *(Takes out her pad.)*

MARK: Well-how about some O.J.

WAITRESS: Sorry. Squeezer's broken.

MARK: A glass of milk?

WAITRESS: Cow's dry.

MARK: Cuppa coffee?

WAITRESS: Oh we don't have that, sir. *(The WAITRESS has spoken the magic words.)*

MARK: That's too bad. *(exchanges a look and nod with the audience)* How about a Heineken?

WAITRESS: Heineken? Try again.

MARK: Bud Lite?

WAITRESS: Just plain Bud is all we got.

MARK: No thanks.

WAITRESS: *(Calls.)* Gimme a Bud! *(to MARK)* Anything to eat?

MARK: Pork chops.

WAITRESS: *(Writes down.)* Hamburger. . .

MARK: Medium.

WAITRESS: Well done. . .

MARK: Baked potato.

WAITRESS: Fries . . . *(Exits, calling.)* Burn one!

AL: Excellent. You sure you've never done this before?

MARK: I've spent so much of my life asking for the wrong thing without knowing it, doing it on purpose comes easy. I could've saved myself a lot of trouble if I'd screwed up on purpose all those years. Maybe I was in a Philadelphia all along and never knew it!

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AL: You might've been in a Baltimore. They're practically the same. *(WAITRESS enters, with a glass of beer and a plate.)*

WAITRESS: Okay. Here's your Bud. *(Sets that in front of MARK.)* And one cheese steak. *(She sets that in front of AL, and starts to go.)*

AL: Excuse me. Hey. Wait a minute. What is that?

WAITRESS: It's a cheese steak.

AL: No. I ordered cream of kidney.

WAITRESS: Oh we don't have that, sir.

AL: I beg your pardon? *(to MARK.)* You son of a bitch! I'm in your Philadelphia!

MARK: I'm sorry, Al. I didn't know it was contagious.

AL: Oh God, please don't let me be in a Philadelphia! Don't let me be in a Philadelphia!

MARK: But maybe you're not really in a Philadelphia!

AL: Do you see the cheese on that steak? What do I need for proof? The Liberty Bell? Waitress, bring me a glass of water.

WAITRESS: Water? Don't have that, sir.

AL: *(to MARK)* "We don't have water"-? What, you think we're in a sudden drought or something? *(Suddenly realizes)* Holy ****, I just lost my job. . . ! Susie left me! I gotta make some phone calls! *(to WAITRESS)* 'Scuse me, where's the pay phone?

WAITRESS: Sorry, we don't have a pay phone

AL: Of course you don't have a pay phone, of course you don't! Oh *****, let me outa here! *(Exits.)*

MARK: I don't know. It's not that bad in a Philadelphia.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier
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